

Camp Cheat (often referring to **Cheat Summit Fort / Fort Milroy** on Cheat Mountain, WV) and **Fort Duffield** at West Point, KY share some broad similarities as early-war Union positions, but they differ sharply in purpose, terrain, and construction. A side-by-side look makes the relationship clearer.

High-Level Comparison

Feature	Camp Cheat / Cheat Summit Fort	Fort Duffield (West Point, KY)
Date Built	Summer 1861	Fall 1861
Primary Purpose	Protect the Staunton–Parkersburg Turnpike; block Confederate movement through the Alleghenies	Protect the L&N Railroad, West Point supply depot, and Louisville from Confederate attack
Elevation & Terrain	Extremely high elevation (~4,000 ft), cold, foggy, remote	High ridge above West Point (~300 ft above town), overlooking Ohio & Salt Rivers
Garrison Size	~300–1,800 depending on phase	~1,000–2,000 rotating troops
Fort Type	Mountain-top log fortification with rifle pits and blockhouses	Earthwork fort with long rifle trenches, bastions, and artillery positions
Living Conditions	Harsh weather, isolation, disease, supply difficulty	Difficult but less extreme; closer to supply lines and town
Combat History	Site of the 1861 Battle of Cheat Mountain; successfully repelled Lee's first offensive	No major battle; served as a defensive stronghold and supply protection point

Key Similarities

1. Strategic High Ground

Both were placed on commanding heights to control key transportation routes:

- Cheat Summit Fort guarded a mountain turnpike.
- Fort Duffield guarded the L&N Railroad and the confluence of two rivers.

2. Early-War Union Defensive Mindset

Both reflect the Union's 1861 priority: **secure supply lines and block Confederate movement** before large armies were fully organized.

3. Harsh Construction Conditions

Troops at both sites built their forts under:

- Cold or Wet Weather
- Shortages of tools
- Disease outbreaks
- Inexperienced volunteer regiments

Key Differences

1. Scale and Engineering

Cheat Summit Fort was a **log-and-earth mountain fort**, smaller and more isolated. Fort Duffield was a **large, engineered earthwork**, with long trenches, artillery angles, and a more formal layout—closer to what you’d expect from a semi-permanent defensive fort.

2. Operational Role

- **Camp Cheat** was an *active combat outpost* that directly faced Confederate attacks.
- **Fort Duffield** was a *protective shield* for a vital supply hub; its mere presence deterred attack.

3. Environment

Cheat Mountain’s extreme weather made it one of the most miserable Union posts of 1861. Fort Duffield’s conditions were tough but not nearly as brutal.

Bottom Line

Yes, Camp Cheat and Fort Duffield are similar in that they were early-war Union defensive positions built on high ground to protect key transportation routes. But Cheat Summit Fort was a remote mountain combat post, while Fort Duffield was a major earthwork guarding a strategic supply line and town.